

AMBIENT ELECTRONICS

Your Hidden Helper

Research on miniaturisation of hardware, information processing, wireless communication, human-machine interfaces, etc is taking us closer to the 'ambient electronics' dream



Control4 home automation system

■ JANANI GOPALAKRISHNAN VIKRAM

Let me take you through a smart home. The lights switch on when you enter and turn off when you leave. The music system automatically reduces the volume when your phone rings or you call somebody. Energy usage monitors keep displaying your electricity consumption so that you can reduce it. Alarm clocks synchronise automatically with Inter-

net-time and even give you the day's weather forecast when you get up. The moment your feet land on the mat, the heater switches on automatically, and so does your electric coffee kettle. You can access your computer with your dining table—well, the tabletop acts just like a tablet PC that emulates your laptop. Your wardrobe is enabled with software that helps you select your clothes for the day. You can order your car to come to your door. Your car itself is full of

gadgets that tell you the way to your destination, entertain you and let you work. When you step out, you are accosted by smart meters in parking lots, automated traffic signals, and cameras to check your speed and general driving discipline. In short, you are surrounded by devices—or rather, an Internet of things—that mingle with you, help you and enhance your life! But would that not be a scary mess of silicon and copper?

Well, not really! And that is what